

Vayairah 5786 (2)

I was looking at the end of וַיֵּרָא for a vort on the עקדה because it's the עקדה. The ספר אוצר פלאות התורה brings a fascinating question: Did גומל bentch יצחק אבינו after the עקדה? Did you ever think of that?

The ספר in his חיד"א called מוזיק ברכה brings down a dream that a גאון whose name was נחום had, in which he saw the father of the חיד"א, his name was רבי יצחק זרחיה אזולאי. רבי יצחק זרחיה asked him, "Did יצחק bentch גומל after the עקדה?" The חיד"א writes that his father did not give him any answer, however, when he woke up, he himself came to his own conclusion that it was not necessary for יצחק to bentch גומל, even though he was face-to-face with death. It would be appropriate to bentch גומל, but the עקדה was done as a direct מצוה of הקדוש ברוך הוא. It was being דבר המלך ודחו, and you don't have to bentch גומל for that.

Now, listen to this. According to the אוצר פלאות התורה, who bentchs גומל when they recover from an illness? We don't פסקן like this, but he says that if someone was deathly ill, was already a גוסס and he became well, he is required to bentch גומל. However, let's say the man died and came back to life. That is a fascinating circumstance on which there's been a tremendous amount of literature in the last 20 - 30 years about near-death experiences, where people actually died and came back and told us what their experiences were in the other world. We happen to know from other ספרים that such a phenomenon exists, that people die and come back to life. That person does not bentch גומל, rather makes the ברכה of מחיה המתים. He brings down from the דברי אליעזר and פרקי דרבי אליעזר, that after יצחק אבינו went through the experience of the עקדה, he made the bracha of מחיה מתים. That's a well-known מדרש. Now, this is the לשון of פרקי דרבי אליעזר.

When the חרב came close and was actually touching his neck, יצחק's נשמה left him, and when he heard the voice of הקדוש ברוך הוא through the מלאך saying אֵל הַנֶּעֱרָא, אֵל תְּשַׁלַּח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנֶּעֱרָא, his נשמה came back to his body. Then יצחק got up and he said, "I now know that there is such a concept as תחיית המתים", and he made the ברכה of תחיית המתים. So as far as we know, יצחק אבינו was the first one to experience תחיית המתים.

